

E4 Support Style Discovery

Formerly: "Help Me, Help You" Exchange. Rebuilt with clearer purpose: understanding what kind of support each team member actually needs.

Pillar	Enablement	Difficulty	Level 1
Time Required	30-40 minutes	Group Size	4-10
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	None	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Lack of leadership support signals, feeling unsupported, disconnect between manager help and what team members actually need

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

The brain's response to receiving help depends entirely on whether the help matches what the person needs. Unsolicited advice when someone needs emotional support triggers cortisol (the person feels unheard). Empathetic listening when someone needs a practical solution triggers frustration (the person feels their problem isn't being taken seriously).

Most managers default to one support style: the problem-solver who gives advice, or the empathetic listener who validates feelings. Neither is universally correct. This exercise maps each person's preferred support style so the manager (and the team) can match the response to the need.

The Exercise

Phase 1: Support Style Self-Assessment (10 minutes)

Each person privately identifies their preferred support style when they're struggling at work:

Style	What It Sounds Like
Direct Problem Solver	"I want practical help. Give me options, resources, or take something off my plate. I don't need to talk about how I feel about it."
Empathetic Listener	"I need to be heard first. Let me talk through it. Don't jump to solutions until I've had a chance to process."
Thinking Partner	"I need someone to think with, not think for me. Ask me questions. Help me see what I'm missing. Don't give me the answer."

Space Giver	"I need time and space to figure it out myself. Check in later but don't hover. I'll come to you if I need help."
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Most people have a primary and a secondary style. Some switch depending on the type of struggle (technical problems may need a Problem Solver; interpersonal issues may need a Listener).

Phase 2: Sharing Round (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Share your primary support style and, if you're comfortable, give an example of a time when someone helped you in a way that really worked, and a time when someone tried to help but it didn't land because it wasn't what you needed."

The manager captures a simple team reference: each person's name and their preferred style(s). This becomes a team resource that guides how people support each other.

Phase 3: The Manager's Support Audit (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Now I need honest feedback. When you've come to me with a problem, how well has my support style matched what you needed? Where have I got it right, and where have I defaulted to my own style instead of matching yours?"

This is a vulnerability moment for the manager. The team's honest feedback here directly improves the manager's effectiveness. Commit to one adaptation: "I tend to jump to solutions. When you come to me, I'll start by asking 'Do you want me to help solve this or help you think through it?' before I respond."

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
Someone says "I don't need help from anyone"	Reframe: "Independence is a strength. The question isn't whether you need help. It's whether, when things are genuinely difficult, you know what kind of support would be most useful, and whether the team knows how to provide it. Even the Space Giver style is a form of support: it's the support of not being hovered over."
The manager's default style doesn't match most of the team	This is the most valuable outcome of the exercise. "I can see that my default is Problem Solver and most of you need Thinking Partner or Listener first. That's a concrete thing I can change. From now on, I'll ask before I default."

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
C8: Communication Preferences	E4 maps support preferences; C8 maps communication preferences. Together they give the manager a complete guide to each team member.	Complementary
V9: Cultivating Empathy	Empathy is the skill that enables matching support to need. V9 builds the capability; E4 provides the data.	Complementary
V11: Workload Struggles	When someone raises a workload issue, knowing their support style determines whether to problem-solve, listen, think with them, or give space.	E4 supports V11